Chronology

There is considerable debate among scholars about the age and chronology of Sangam society. The Sangam texts are generally dated to between third century BC (BC (BCE)) and the third century AD (CE). The references in Greco-Roman texts, Tamil-Brahmi inscriptions and the references to the Cheras, Cholas and the Pandyas in the **Ashokan** inscription corroborate this date. It is generally agreed that the Sangam poems were composed in the early part of the historical period, but were compiled into anthologies in the later period.

Ashokan Brahmi - the Brahmi script used in Ashokan edicts or inscriptions.

The Thinai

The concept of *Thinai* is presented in the Tamil Grammar work of *Tholkappiyam* and this concept is essential to understand the classical Tamil poems. *Thinai* is a poetic theme, which means a class or category and refers to a habitat or eco-zone with specific physiographical characteristics. Sangam poems are set in these specific eco-zones and reveal that human life has deep relationships with nature.

The themes of the poems are broadly defined as *akam* (interior) and *puram* (exterior). *Akathinai* refers to various situations of love and family life, while *Purathinai* is concerned with all others aspects of life and deals particularly with war and heroism.

Ainthinai: The Five *Thinais* or landscapes.

Tamilagam was divided into five landscapes. Each region had distinct characteristics – a presiding deity, occupation, people and cultural life according to its specific environmental conditions. This classification has been interpreted by scholars to reflect real life situations in these landscapes.

The five landscapes are *Kurunji, Mullai, Marutham, Neythal and Paalai.*

- *Kurunji* refers to the hilly and mountainous region.
- *Mullai* is forested and pastoral region.
- *Marutham* is the fertile riverine valley.
- *Neythal* is coastal region.
- *Paalai* is sandy desert region.

3.3 Sangam Age Polity: Political Powers of Tamilagam

The Sangam Age has its roots in the Iron Age. In the Iron Age people were organised into **chiefdoms**. From such communities of Iron Age emerged the Vendhars of the early historic period and the Velirs of the Sangam Age were chieftains.

The Mauryan emperor, Asoka, conquered Kalinga (Odisha) and parts of Andhra and Karnataka regions.

The Muvendhar

Among the political powers of the Sangam Age, the Cheras, the Cholas and the Pandyas occupied pre-eminent positions. They were known as *Muvendhar* (the three kings). The *muvendhar* controlled the major towns and ports of the Sangam period.

The Cheras

The Cheras, referred to as Keralaputras in the Ashokan inscriptions, controlled the region of present-day Kerala and also the western parts of Tamil Nadu. Vanci was the capital of the Cheras while Muciri and Thondi were their port towns. Vanci is identified with Karur in Tamil Nadu while some others identify it with Thiruvanchaikkalam in Kerala. *Pathirtruppathu* speaks about the Chera kings and their territory. The Cheras wore



A Chera coin with bow and arrow, and an elephant goad on the obverse and elephant on the reverse

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